

But our long-term goal will be to free you financially so that Naomi can stay home to be a full-time mom if she wants to be. And you should set up a retirement plan.”

“But we have tried that before. Every time I quit working we fell further and further behind,” Naomi said.

“That’s because you started out with expenses larger than your income. I believe you’ll find when you readjust your budget that you’ll be able to get by on one income. Later, if you want to return to the workplace, you should use your income only for one-time purchases.”

“What do you mean?” asked Ben.

“Save it and buy a car, or save it for a down payment on a home, but don’t commit yourselves to monthly expenses based on two incomes, especially at your age.”

“That’s one lesson we’ve learned the hard way,” Ben replied, looking at Naomi.

“I want you to go home with the plan I have given you and make the necessary adjustments in your budget. Remember that each and every category of spending must have some money allocated to it. To ignore areas like entertainment and recreation is unrealistic and will cause your budget to fail within a short period of time. Ignoring needs like clothing, auto repairs, and dental bills will make your budget look good but will also make it totally unrealistic.”

“What about giving?” Naomi asked. “I always tithed before I was married, but we’ve been unable to for most of our marriage.”

“Tithing is an important principle for a Christian; it demonstrates a commitment to God in the most visible area of our lives: money. But God wants you to honor your word also. You have made an agreement with the court to pay your creditors according to the budget you submitted, so you must do so. One part of your long-term plan should be to reduce your monthly expenses so that later you can give God His portion too. But for now you’ll have to stick to the plan you have. I believe God will honor the commitment in both of your hearts. He doesn’t care about the money nearly as much as